

RBF-FD Solver: Least Squares Method for Operator Reproduction

Dennis Corraliza

Updated: 9/16/25

1 Problem Setting:

Following the standard RBF-FD methods, let $u \in \mathcal{F}$ be a solution for a PDE in form of:

$$-Lu = -\nabla \cdot (A \nabla u) = f \quad \text{in } \Omega, \quad (1)$$

Let $1 < p < \infty$, $A \in W^{1,\infty}(\bar{\Omega}; \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}) : \bar{\Omega} \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^{d \times d}$ is an symmetric positive definite anisotropic tensor, where

$$\eta |\xi|^2 \leq \mathbf{A}(\mathbf{x}) \xi \cdot \xi \leq \mathbf{H} |\xi|^2, \quad \mathbf{0} < \eta \leq \mathbf{H} \quad (2)$$

Assume $\Omega \subset \mathbb{R}^d$ and $f \in W^{k,p}(\Omega)$ is the forcing term acting in the domain Ω . The problem is subject to Neumann and Dirichlet Boundary Conditions partitioned within $\partial\Omega$ of the form:

$$u = g_D \quad \text{on } \Gamma_D \subset \partial\Omega, \quad (3)$$

$$n \cdot A \nabla u = g_N \quad \text{on } \Gamma_N \subset \partial\Omega, \quad (4)$$

For simplicity, we assume Ω be a bounded $C^{1,1}(\partial\Omega)$ domain, with $\partial\Omega = \Gamma_D \cup \Gamma_N$ and $\Gamma_D \cap \Gamma_N = \emptyset$. Furthermore, let $g_D \in W^{k-1/p,p}(\partial\Omega)$, $g_N \in W^{k-1-1/p,p}(\partial\Omega)$. By *Agmon-Douglis-Nirenberg* Theorem [2], we have the following estimate for u :

$$\|u\|_{W^{k,p}(\Omega)} \leq C \left(\|Lu\|_{W^{k-2,p}(\Omega)} + \|g_D\|_{W^{k-1/p,p}(\partial\Omega)} + \|g_N\|_{W^{k-1-1/p,p}(\partial\Omega)} + \|u\|_{L^p(\Omega)} \right). \quad (5)$$

In the case that we work on a Hilbert space, we then have for $p = 2$ ($W^{k,2} := H^k$) the following estimate for u :

$$\|u\|_{H^k(\Omega)} \leq C \left(\|Lu\|_{H^{k-2}(\Omega)} + \|g_D\|_{H^{k-\frac{1}{2}}(\partial\Omega)} + \|g_N\|_{H^{k-\frac{3}{2}}(\partial\Omega)} + \|u\|_{L^2(\Omega)} \right). \quad (6)$$

If we want to study cases where $(Lu)(\mathbf{x}) \in L^\infty(\Omega)$. we can formulate the setup by having $f \in W^{s,p}(\Omega)$ and, by Morrey Embedding,

$$W^{s,p} \hookrightarrow C^{0,\alpha}, \quad \text{with } \alpha = s - \frac{d}{p} > 0 \quad (7)$$

In other words, $s > \frac{d}{p}$. Suppose $p = 2$, then $s > \frac{d}{2}$. Given an operator $L : H^{s+2}(\Omega) \rightarrow H^s(\Omega)$, we define an error functional of the form:

$$\xi_{L,x} : H^{s+2}(\Omega) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}, \quad \xi_{L,x} \in (H^{s+2})^*(\Omega) \quad (8)$$

Then by Riesz Representation Theorem, there exists a $v_{L,x} \in H^{s+2}(\Omega)$ such that $\xi_{L,x}(u) = \langle u, v_{L,x} \rangle_{H^{s+2}(\Omega)}$, and $\|\xi_{L,x}\|_{(H^{s+2}(\Omega))^*} = \|v_{L,x}\|_{H^{s+2}(\Omega)}$

2 RBF-FD Method:

2.1 Local Approximation setup

To obtain an approximation of the operator L at point $\mathbf{z}$, we can approximate $\hat{u} \approx u$ on a neighborhood $\Omega \subseteq \mathbb{R}^d$ of $\mathbf{z}$ such that we approximate $Lu \approx L\hat{u}$. We define the radial basis functions in the form $\phi_i(\mathbf{x}) := \phi(\|\mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}_i\|) : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ for $i = 1, \dots, m$ and centers $\{\mathbf{y}_i\}_{i=1}^m \subseteq \Omega$. Define the vector space $V_Y = \text{span}\{\phi_1, \dots, \phi_m\}$. Let $X = \{\mathbf{x}_1, \dots, \mathbf{x}_n\} \subseteq \Omega$ be a set of stencil nodes for a point $\mathbf{z}$ in Ω . For the classical approximation scheme, let $X = Y$ and $m = n$. We can now define $\Phi \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times m}$, where $\Phi_{ij} = \phi_j(\mathbf{x}_i)$. The role of these basis functions will be to approximate the operator L . The approximation of u takes the form of:

$$\hat{u}(\mathbf{x}) = \sum_{i=1}^n \lambda_i \phi_i(\mathbf{x}) \quad (9)$$

This will lead to the form $\Phi \lambda = \hat{\mathbf{u}}$ for $\hat{\mathbf{u}} = [u(\mathbf{x}_1), \dots, u(\mathbf{x}_n)]^T$. We can simplify for λ to obtain:

$$\hat{u}(\mathbf{x}) = \sum_{i=1}^n (\Phi^{-1} \mathbf{u})_i \phi_i(\mathbf{x}) = \phi(\mathbf{x})^T \Phi^{-1} \mathbf{u} \quad (10)$$

The approximation of Lu at $\mathbf{z}$ is in the form of:

$$Lu(\mathbf{z}) \approx \mathbf{L} \hat{\mathbf{u}}(\mathbf{z}) = \mathbf{L} \phi^T(\mathbf{z}) \lambda = \mathbf{L} \phi^T(\mathbf{z}) \Phi^{-1} \mathbf{u} := \mathbf{w}^{\mathbf{L}, \mathbf{X}}(\mathbf{z}) \mathbf{u} \quad (11)$$

Thus, approximation the operator turns into local solver for the weights w_i from the form:

$$\Phi^T \mathbf{w}^{\mathbf{L}, \mathbf{X}}(\mathbf{z}) = \mathbf{L} \phi(\mathbf{z}) \quad (12)$$

Through the method of undefined coefficients on the basis $\{\phi_i\}$ we get the same resulting set of weights. Finally, by defining the basis for V_Y as radial basis functions, we get the Radial Basis Function generated Finite Difference method (RBF-FD).

2.2 Polynomial Augmentation

For conditionally positive definite kernels, we augment them through the form:

$$\hat{u}(\mathbf{x}) = \sum_{j=1}^n \lambda_j \phi_j(\mathbf{x}) + \sum_{j=1}^l \beta_j \mathbf{p}_j(\mathbf{x}) \quad (13)$$

We can generate a Gram matrix equation of the form:

$$\begin{bmatrix} \hat{\mathbf{u}} \\ \mathbf{0} \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} \Phi & \mathbf{P} \\ \mathbf{P}^T & \mathbf{0} \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} \lambda \\ \alpha \end{bmatrix} \quad (14)$$

Hence, we can approximate the operator to take the form:

$$(L\hat{u})(\mathbf{x}) = \begin{bmatrix} (\mathbf{L}\phi)(\mathbf{x}) \\ (\mathbf{L}\mathbf{p})(\mathbf{x}) \end{bmatrix}^T \begin{bmatrix} \Phi & \mathbf{P} \\ \mathbf{P}^T & \mathbf{0} \end{bmatrix}^{-1} \begin{bmatrix} \hat{\mathbf{u}} \\ \mathbf{0} \end{bmatrix} := \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x}) \hat{\mathbf{u}} \quad (15)$$

The polynomial constraint setup can be viewed as a Lagrange multiplier to a minimization scheme for the weights. Note that depending on the the basis V_Y , we get the degree of $p \in \Pi_{k-1}^d$. Below are common RBFs and their respective cpd orders:

Table 1: Common radial basis functions and their minimal CPD order.

RBF	Radial function $\phi(r)$	CPD order k
Gaussian	$\exp(-\varepsilon^2 r^2)$	0
Inverse multiquadric	$(r^2 + \varepsilon^2)^{-1/2}$	0
Multiquadric	$(r^2 + \varepsilon^2)^{1/2}$	1
Linear	r	1
Cubic	r^3	2
Thin-plate spline	$r^2 \log r$	2
Quintic	r^5	3

This order provides us both, the degree of the polynomials $k - 1$ and the number of terms:

$$l = \binom{d + k - 1}{k - 1} \quad (16)$$

As shown in [8], a polynomial augmentation can be added with a larger degree than required for the RBF, acting as a correction term while inheriting the non-oscillatory behavior of the RBF at the boundary $\partial\Omega$.

2.3 Consistency Error Analysis

We begin by defining the native space of solutions for (1) with (4). Suppose $\mathcal{F}_K = W^{k,p}$.

RKHS is a Hilbert space with bounded evaluation functionals. Thus, we have a kernel definition.

We begin by defining the native space for the set of solutions for (1) with (4). Let $\mathcal{F}_K$ be the RKHS Native space for the set of solutions. Suppose $V_Y \subseteq V = \text{span} \{ \phi(\cdot, \mathbf{x}) : \mathbf{x} \in \Omega \subseteq \mathbb{R}^d \} \subseteq \mathcal{F}_K$. Let $f \in \mathcal{F}_K$, then $f(x) = \langle f, \phi(\cdot, \mathbf{x}) \rangle_{\mathcal{F}_K}$. Then $(Lf)(x) = \langle f, L\phi(\cdot, \mathbf{x}) \rangle_{\mathcal{F}_K}$. Additionally, $\mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})\mathbf{f} = \langle f, \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})\phi \rangle_{\mathcal{F}_K}$. Defining the error functional $\xi_{w,x}(f) = \sup_{f \in \mathcal{F}_K, \|f\|_{\mathcal{F}_K} \leq 1} |Lf(x) - \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})\mathbf{f}| < \infty$ and $\xi_{w,x} \in \mathcal{F}_K^*$. Therefore, by Riesz Representation Theorem, $g_{w,x} = L\phi(\cdot, \mathbf{x}) - \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})\phi$, $\xi_{w,x} = \|g_{w,x}\|_{\mathcal{F}_K}$. Finally, We define the power function $\mathcal{P}^2(x) = \|g_{w,x}\|_{\mathcal{F}_K}^2$.

3 Weight Constraint RBF-FD Setup:

Rather than assuming a form for the solution, our goal is to approximate the operator through weights dual to u sampled at nodes. Suppose $m > n$ (for the case of $m < n$, refer to [1]), thus more center nodes than stencil nodes per stencil. Additionally, instead of assuming exactness of the form $L\phi_j(\mathbf{x}) = \sum_i^n w_i(\mathbf{x})\phi_j(\mathbf{x}_i)$ for $j = 1, \dots, m$ as in the classical RBF-FD, we define a residual function:

$$r_j(\mathbf{x}) := L\phi_j(\mathbf{x}) - \sum_{i=1}^n w_i(\mathbf{x})\phi_j(\mathbf{x}_i) \quad (17)$$

$$r(\mathbf{x}) = L\phi(\mathbf{x}) - \Phi^T \mathbf{w}(\mathbf{x}), \quad \mathbf{w} : \mathbb{R}^n \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n \text{ for } \mathbf{x} \in \Omega. \quad (18)$$

Suppose $\{p_i\}_{i=1}^l$ is a set of polynomials augmenting the radial basis functions. Let $\Pi_k = \text{span} \{p_i\}_{i=1}^l$ with polynomial degree up to k . We want to reproduce the operator exactly on the

polynomial basis:

$$Lp_j(\mathbf{x}) := \sum_{i=1}^n w_i(\mathbf{x}) p_j(\mathbf{x}_i) \text{ for } j = 1, \dots, l \quad (19)$$

$$L\mathbf{p}(\mathbf{x}) = \mathbf{P}^T \mathbf{w} \quad (20)$$

where $\mathbf{P}_{ij} := p_j(\mathbf{x}_i) \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times l}$. Thus, we have a constrained least squares problem in the form:

$$\begin{cases} \min J(\mathbf{w}(\mathbf{x})) := \min \frac{1}{2} \|\mathbf{r}(\mathbf{x})\|_2^2 & \text{for } \mathbf{x} \in \Omega \\ \text{subject to } \mathbf{\Phi}^T \mathbf{w} = L\mathbf{p} \end{cases} \quad (21)$$

We can solve this setup by defining the Lagrangian $\mathcal{L}$ for the problem as follows:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{L}(\mathbf{w}, \boldsymbol{\nu}) &:= J(\mathbf{w}) + \langle \boldsymbol{\nu}, \mathbf{P}^T \mathbf{w} - L\mathbf{p}(\mathbf{x}) \rangle \\ &= \frac{1}{2} \langle \mathbf{\Phi}^T \mathbf{w}, \mathbf{\Phi}^T \mathbf{w} \rangle - \langle \mathbf{\Phi}^T \mathbf{w}, L\phi \rangle + \frac{1}{2} \langle L\phi, L\phi \rangle \\ &\quad + \langle \boldsymbol{\nu}, \mathbf{P}^T \mathbf{w} - L\mathbf{p}(\mathbf{x}) \rangle. \end{aligned}$$

4 Consistency Conditions for Finite Spaces and Interpolation Results

The resulting KKT equations for this system are then:

$$\nabla_{\mathbf{w}} \mathcal{L} = 0 : \mathbf{\Phi} L\phi = \mathbf{\Phi} \mathbf{\Phi}^T \mathbf{w} + \mathbf{P} \boldsymbol{\nu} \quad (22)$$

$$\nabla_{\boldsymbol{\nu}} \mathcal{L} = 0 : \mathbf{P}^T \mathbf{w} = L\mathbf{p} \quad (23)$$

The augmented matrix then takes the form:

$$\begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{\Phi} \mathbf{\Phi}^T & \mathbf{P} \\ \mathbf{P}^T & \mathbf{0} \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{w} \\ \boldsymbol{\nu} \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{\Phi} L\phi \\ L\mathbf{p} \end{bmatrix} \quad (24)$$

From [6], Equation (24) has a unique solution given $L\mathbf{p} \in \text{Range}(\mathbf{P}^T)$. The primary goal is to approximate $Lu(\mathbf{x}) \approx \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})\mathbf{u}$, with $\mathbf{u} = [u(\mathbf{x}_1), \dots, u(\mathbf{x}_n)]^T$. Define $L_h f(\mathbf{x}) := \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})\mathbf{f}$ for some function f . Thus, we have the following:

$$\begin{aligned} L_h f(\mathbf{x}) &= \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})\mathbf{f} \\ &= [\mathbf{w}^T \quad \boldsymbol{\nu}^T] \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{f} \\ \mathbf{0} \end{bmatrix} \\ &= \left(\begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{\Phi} \mathbf{\Phi}^T & \mathbf{P} \\ \mathbf{P}^T & \mathbf{0} \end{bmatrix}^{-1} \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{\Phi} L\phi \\ L\mathbf{p} \end{bmatrix} \right)^T \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{f} \\ \mathbf{0} \end{bmatrix} \\ &= [L\phi^T \mathbf{\Phi}^T \quad L\mathbf{p}^T] \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{\Phi} \mathbf{\Phi}^T & \mathbf{P} \\ \mathbf{P}^T & \mathbf{0} \end{bmatrix}^{-T} \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{f} \\ \mathbf{0} \end{bmatrix} \\ &= [L\phi^T \mathbf{\Phi}^T \quad L\mathbf{p}^T] \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{q} \\ \boldsymbol{\alpha} \end{bmatrix} \\ &= L\phi^T(\mathbf{x}) (\mathbf{\Phi}^T \mathbf{q}) + L\mathbf{p}^T(\mathbf{x}) \boldsymbol{\alpha} \end{aligned}$$

Next, we can show that the coefficients $\mathbf{q}, \boldsymbol{\alpha}$ relate to the coefficients of u as follows:

$$\begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{f} \\ \mathbf{0} \end{bmatrix} = \begin{bmatrix} \boldsymbol{\Phi}\boldsymbol{\Phi}^T & \mathbf{P} \\ \mathbf{P}^T & \mathbf{0} \end{bmatrix} \begin{bmatrix} \mathbf{q} \\ \boldsymbol{\alpha} \end{bmatrix} \quad (25)$$

Define $V_h = \{\rho(x) : \rho(x) = \sum_{i=1}^m \lambda_i \phi_i(x) \text{ such that } \lambda \in \text{Range}(\boldsymbol{\Phi}^T)\} \subseteq V_Y$. Let $s \in V_h + \Pi_k$. Thus, $s(x) = \boldsymbol{\phi}^T(\mathbf{x})\boldsymbol{\Phi}^T\mathbf{q} + \mathbf{p}^T(\mathbf{x})\boldsymbol{\alpha}$ where $\mathbf{q} \in \mathbb{R}^n$ and $\boldsymbol{\alpha} \in \mathbb{R}^l$. Then:

$$\mathbf{s} = s(X) = \boldsymbol{\Phi}\boldsymbol{\Phi}^T\mathbf{q} + \mathbf{P}\boldsymbol{\alpha} = f(X) = \mathbf{f} \quad (26)$$

$$\mathbf{P}^T\mathbf{q} = \mathbf{0} \quad (27)$$

Hence, we get interpolation of f at the node set X . Furthermore, from the KKT matrix we can show that $\boldsymbol{\Phi}\mathbf{r} = \mathbf{P}\boldsymbol{\nu}$ which implies that $\boldsymbol{\Phi}\mathbf{r} \in \text{range}(\mathbf{P}) = (\ker(\mathbf{P}^T))^\perp$. Thus, we get the relationship:

$$\mathbf{r}^T(\boldsymbol{\Phi}^T\mathbf{z}) = \mathbf{0} \text{ for } \mathbf{P}^T\mathbf{z} = \mathbf{0} \quad (28)$$

Finally, we check the consistency error for $s \in V_h + \Pi_k$ with $\mathbf{P}^T\mathbf{q} = \mathbf{0}$.

$$\begin{aligned} Ls(x) - L_h s(x) &= L(\boldsymbol{\phi}^T(\mathbf{x})\boldsymbol{\Phi}^T\mathbf{q} + \mathbf{p}^T(\mathbf{x})\boldsymbol{\alpha}) - \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})\mathbf{s} \\ &= L\boldsymbol{\phi}^T(\mathbf{x})\boldsymbol{\Phi}^T\mathbf{q} + L\mathbf{p}^T(\mathbf{x})\boldsymbol{\alpha} - \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})(\boldsymbol{\Phi}\boldsymbol{\Phi}^T\mathbf{q} + \mathbf{P}\boldsymbol{\alpha}) \\ &= L\boldsymbol{\phi}^T(\mathbf{x})\boldsymbol{\Phi}^T\mathbf{q} + L\mathbf{p}^T(\mathbf{x})\boldsymbol{\alpha} - \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})\boldsymbol{\Phi}\boldsymbol{\Phi}^T\mathbf{q} - \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})\mathbf{P}\boldsymbol{\alpha} \\ &= (L\boldsymbol{\phi}(\mathbf{x}) - \boldsymbol{\Phi}^T\mathbf{w}(\mathbf{x}))^T \boldsymbol{\Phi}^T\mathbf{q} + (L\mathbf{p}^T(\mathbf{x}) - \mathbf{P}^T\mathbf{w}(\mathbf{x}))^T \boldsymbol{\alpha} \\ &= \mathbf{r}^T\boldsymbol{\Phi}^T\mathbf{q} + (L\mathbf{p}(\mathbf{x}) - \mathbf{P}^T\mathbf{w}(\mathbf{x}))^T \boldsymbol{\alpha} \end{aligned}$$

$$Ls(x) - L_h s(x) = 0 \text{ due to (23) and (28)} \quad (29)$$

5 Consistency Results for Function Approximations

Let u be a solution to (1) and $s \in V_h + \Pi_k$. We can say $u = s + (u - s)$ to get the following:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{E}[u](\mathbf{x}) &:= Lu(\mathbf{x}) - L_h u(\mathbf{x}) \\ &= Lu(\mathbf{x}) - \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})\mathbf{u} \\ &= L((u - s) + s)(\mathbf{x}) - \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})\mathbf{u} - L_h s(\mathbf{x}) + L_h s(\mathbf{x}) \\ &= L(u - s)(\mathbf{x}) + (Ls(\mathbf{x}) - L_h s(\mathbf{x})) + L_h(s - u)(\mathbf{x}) \\ &= L(u - s)(\mathbf{x}) - \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})(\mathbf{u} - \mathbf{s}), \text{ by (29)} \\ &= Le(\mathbf{x}) - \mathbf{w}^T(\mathbf{x})\mathbf{e}, \mathbf{e}(\mathbf{x}) = u(\mathbf{x}) - s(\mathbf{x}) \\ &= \mathcal{E}[\mathbf{e}](\mathbf{x}) \end{aligned}$$

References

- [1] Slak, J. (2026). *Adaptive RBF-FD method*. PhD Thesis, University of Ljubljana.
- [2] Agmon, S., Douglis, A. and Nirenberg, L. (1959). *Estimates near the boundary for solutions of elliptic partial differential equations satisfying general boundary conditions*. I. Comm. Pure Appl. Math., 12: 623-727.
<https://doi.org/10.1002/cpa.3160120405>
- [3] Petras, A., Ling, L., Piret, C. and Ruuth, S. J. (2018). *A least-squares implicit RBF-FD closest point method and applications to PDEs on moving surfaces*. Journal of Computational Physics, 363: 94–114.
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jcp.2018.02.023>
- [4] Beatson, R., Davydov, O. and Levesley, J. (2009). *Error bounds for anisotropic RBF interpolation*. Journal of Approximation Theory, 162(1): 1–20.
- [5] Davydov, O. (2025). *Error bounds for numerical differentiation using kernels of finite smoothness*. November 15, 2025.
- [6] Davydov, O. (2020). *Approximation with Conditionally Positive Definite Kernels on Deficient Sets*. arXiv preprint arXiv:2006.13543.
<https://arxiv.org/abs/2006.13543>
- [7] Flyer, N., Fornberg, B., Bayona, V. and Barnett, G. A. (2016). *On the role of polynomials in RBF-FD approximations: I. Interpolation and accuracy*. Journal of Computational Physics, 321: 21–38.
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jcp.2016.05.026>
- [8] Bayona, V. (2019). *An insight into RBF-FD approximations augmented with polynomials*. Computers & Mathematics with Applications, 77(9): 2337–2353.
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.camwa.2018.12.029>